



MUMBAI | Hitting His Own Wicket

Rabble rousing is in his blood. So what if the party performed dismally in the Maharashtra Assembly elections, Shiv Sena supremo Balasaheb Thackeray is making a last ditch attempt to save the party from total ignominy. Taking on the mantle of responsibility to keep his flailing Sena in public memory, Thackeray is using an old formula to attack anything, or anyone, who he thinks comes in his way. This time though he picked on a national hero whose Maharashtrian origin is as accepted as his batting is celebrated. Lashing out at Sachin Tendulkar's harmless comment about Mumbai belonging to all of India, Thackeray found no one in agreement. Dismissing it as an act bordering on "desperation", politicians from most parties in and outside Maharashtra were not amused. Nor was the BCCI. Says Madhav Bhandari, Maharashtra spokesperson for the BJP, "We have distanced ourselves from Balasaheb's comments. Sachin is a respected citizen and has every right to convey his sentiments." Even Thackeray's beloved nephew Raj, the erstwhile torchbearer of all things Marathi, maintained a stoic silence. A senior BJP official from Maharashtra says, "Raj is very smart. His silence speaks for itself. Not only is he good friends with Sachin, he realises this is a non-issue." As in most other matches, in this verbal one too, looks like Tendulkar has hit a six. *by Swati Mathur*

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years is how long Tendulkar has united India while for its 43 years, the Shiv Sena's politics has only created divisions.